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The ‘*Ton-Up Boys*’ of the café racer culture became devoted to early American rock n’ roll music as much as they were to their own motorcycles. Outfitted in British Military surplus leathers, Brylcreem hair styles, and a deep fascination with those illustrious American tunes they heard at the Ace Café earned them the nickname, the “*Rockers*” and they started making front page headlines by the late 1950s. So named due to their penchant for tuning motorcycles to achieve 100 MPH — or “*the Ton*” in British slang — the name became a badge of honour for those capable of achieving this extraordinary, and dangerous, feat. This magazine is dedicated to the fans of the beautiful engineering of café racers.

THE RACE OF GENTLEMEN

On October 20th, we stopped by the shores of Allenhurst and Loch Arbour, NJ to watch “The Race of Gentlemen”. The races consisted of head to head matches between pre-1950 antique cars and motorcycles, stretching $\frac{1}{8}$ th of a mile jetty to jetty on the beach.

TEXT: BANDITA PHOTO: BANDITA

“ Spirited and sporting a crazy beard, he had a remarkable presence to match the event ”



THE EVENT PERIMETER was lined with custom roadsters and antique motorcycles ranging in year, make and model. For \$20 you could step “back in time” from the board walk and enter the race track. The weather was a sunny 70 degrees, perfect race weather. The air had a salty tinge against an ocean back drop mixed with the sound of engines revving and waves smashing onto the beach. Vendors, bands, sexy race gals, and an enthusiastic



the excitement built every time a new contender started his machine.

Meanwhile, the event creator, Meldon Stultz, (a true character) was hard to miss. Spirited and sporting a crazy beard, he had a remarkable presence to match the event. He ran around directing last minute adjustments; such as having sheets of plywood laid down to launch the motorcycles. After rollers and bulldozers packed down the sand and a couple barefooted test runs on his 1939 Indian, it was time.

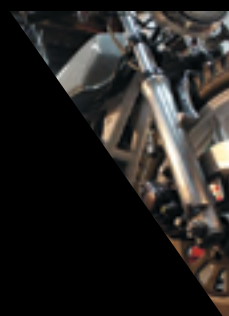
The tides rolled back and the races began. Side by side, motorcyclists battled it out on their beloved machines. I have to say, I witnessed one of the most spirited motorcycle events this year. These races were a pure demonstration of the heart and essence of a true café racer. I'll let the pictures tell you the rest of the story...



announcer dressed in period proper attire completed the picture. Thousands of people were scattered, smiling and pumped with anticipation.

At first, not everything was running smoothly and for a short period of time, there was chatter as to when and how this would even work. Nature didn't want to cooperate and high tide wouldn't leave. On the test runs, motorcycles were getting stuck and sand was flying everywhere. But,





“

BOUGHT THIS BIKE FOR \$600 from a friend that didn't have the time to work on it. It had some good bones so I thought I'd just restore it and flip it over to another friend. Stripped the bike down to see the exact same problem all the other late model cb's and xs's have... A terrible tail. After some quick drawings and some jigging up, I pulled out my scalpel (*a.k.a. my sawzall*) and doctored the tail. Added an inch in the rear, a plug welded hoop, new shock mounts, longer progressive suspension in the rear with a 1 3/4" shortened front end, de-glazed rotor paired with a nice radial set up locks the front up nicely Kept the engine relatively stock since this model Yamaha is prone to oil starvation and I didn't want to tempt fate. Most importantly, I wanted to make this bike look like the old GT BMX bikes with the white Lester wheels... Basically, it's what 5 year old would have wanted.

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IN THE WORDS OF TIM HARNEY...

BUILD SPECIFICATIONS:

1978 Yamaha XS500
Pirelli trail DOT tires
XS powdercoated 19" and 18" wheels
XS650 fork shortened and polished
Custom made clipons/headlight ears
Quick turn flat track throttle
K&N pod filters
KTM dirt bike pegs

XS500 stock tank
Rear end of bike from the frame back is custom bent 1018 cold rolled
Steel plug welded into the powdercoated frame
Integrated tail/turn signals inside the frame hiding the plate quick mount
Kick and electric start (hidden in headlight)

Custom headlight with sealed key start
Stock pipes with stock martini shacker exhausts
Progressive rear suspension
Sealed "o" ring chain
Upholstery by Tim Harney

Father Shergold

A newspaper reporter once accused me of buying a motor bike and a leather jacket as a kind of gimmick to attract teenagers to my church. That is quite true...

TEXT: ANDREW BUNNEY PHOTO: TOMMY



WHEREAS BILL SHERGOLD was very much enjoyed the media spotlight as the face of The 59 Club for the Church of England over Curate John Oakley, the original founder of the London youth club ; for the rebel rocker element, the real heart and soul of The Fifty Nine Club was Father Graham Hullett. Graham was hands on with The Club from 1962 until 1970 staying involved to at least 1973. Yup, it might surprise you to discover that The 59 Club was a church run youth club intended to save the souls of errant yobs— but it was!

Graham was a biker from even before he went into the Army in Germany and a genuine friend to the young rockers. Bailing them out of trouble, enjoying a laugh on the Isle of Man, seeing them through hard times — often out of his own pocket and to his own personal risk — and sharing their love of motorcycles.

We are dedicated to the ongoing memory of Father Graham Hullett, a real biker, and the real story of the rebel rockers of the 59 Club. Although it was certainly the time of their lives for all parties, there were always two sides to the 59 Club. The nice boys who came in from polite suburbs with helmets

and all the latest gear to be part of a scene; and the greasy yobs that rode in hatless and gloveless on whatever hardware they could string together from local estates for the birds. That cohort, that made up what was remembered as “ *The Rockers* “, were the scene;“ ... *a leather jacket did not a Rocker make.* “

So then , who was Rev Shergold?, let the padre tell it in his own words:

A newspaper reporter once accused me of buying a motor bike and a leather jacket as a kind of gimmick to attract teenagers to my church. That is quite untrue. I had a motor bike long before leather jackets had become the rage. In face, my outfit when I first started motor cycling would certainly raise a laugh among the young motor cyclists of today. It consisted of a green beret, long blue police mac, riding breaches and DR boots, all bought at the local surplus stores. As for my bike — a BSA Bantam — I got it simply to get around my parish which at that time was in a new housing area near London Airport.

I was taught to ride by a member of our youth club, Eric Hall, who allowed me to practice on his brand new Douglas Dragonfly. We used to go out in the late evening so that no one could see my escapades. Eventually he decided that I was ready to take my test. I went to Ealing and failed.

The examiner was a woman and I’m convinced that her pet aversions were vicars and motor bikes. In any event, not only did she fail me but, as if to twist the knife in the wound, she informed me that I was a menace to the public. Perhaps I was. But I passed next time — only just, for I ran out of petrol on the way home!

This stage in my motor cycling career could hardly be called successful. The bike was a dead loss. I can’t remember how many times I pushed it from Hanworth to Twickenham for the dealer to tackle the latest fault. One day I was vainly kicking it outside the house of a parishioner. The milkman was chatting on the doorstep and remarked to the woman: “*What a pity vicars aren’t allowed to swear.*” Little did he know...

Twice it broke down on the way to a wedding and I was so embarrassed at conducting marriage services with greasy hands that I decided to sell it and go back to my old push bike.

I was so completely fed up with motorcycles at this stage that I vowed I would never have another one. This resolve I kept until 1959 when the Bishop sent me to take charge of the Eton College Mission at Hackney Wick. This is a big and busy parish and it soon became clear that I must have some form of transportation. Since I had never learned how to drive a car, I decided to take a chance and buy another bike. This time it was a second-hand C15 BSA. It was almost like starting to learn to ride all over again. I used to get up about 4 am and ride around the empty streets. The C15 was a dream after the Bantam, but I wasn’t entirely certain that I had done the right thing in buying a bike.

Perhaps it would have been more in keeping with dignity of a middle-aged vicar to have bought a car and learned to drive. Then my mind was made up for me. I remember the incident quite

“ ... *a leather jacket did not a Rocker make.* ”

vividly. We were having lunch in the Clergy House when the phone rang. A little boy in our Sunday school had been playing in a bombed site and a huge piece of concrete had fallen on his head. He was badly hurt and his parents wanted a priest wanted a priest to visit him at once. I knew I should have to use my bike. It sounded simple enough. But Brentwood was a long way from Hackney and it would mean going along the notoriously busy Eastern Avenue.

There was no time for hesitation and I set off at once. It was a nightmare ride for one so inexperienced, but I got there and was able to pray with the little boy. Incidentally, he made a remarkable recovery. Safely back at the Eton Mission, I was filled with a strange sense of elation. Not only had I conquered my fear of traffic, I had been able to use the bike for doing my work as a priest.

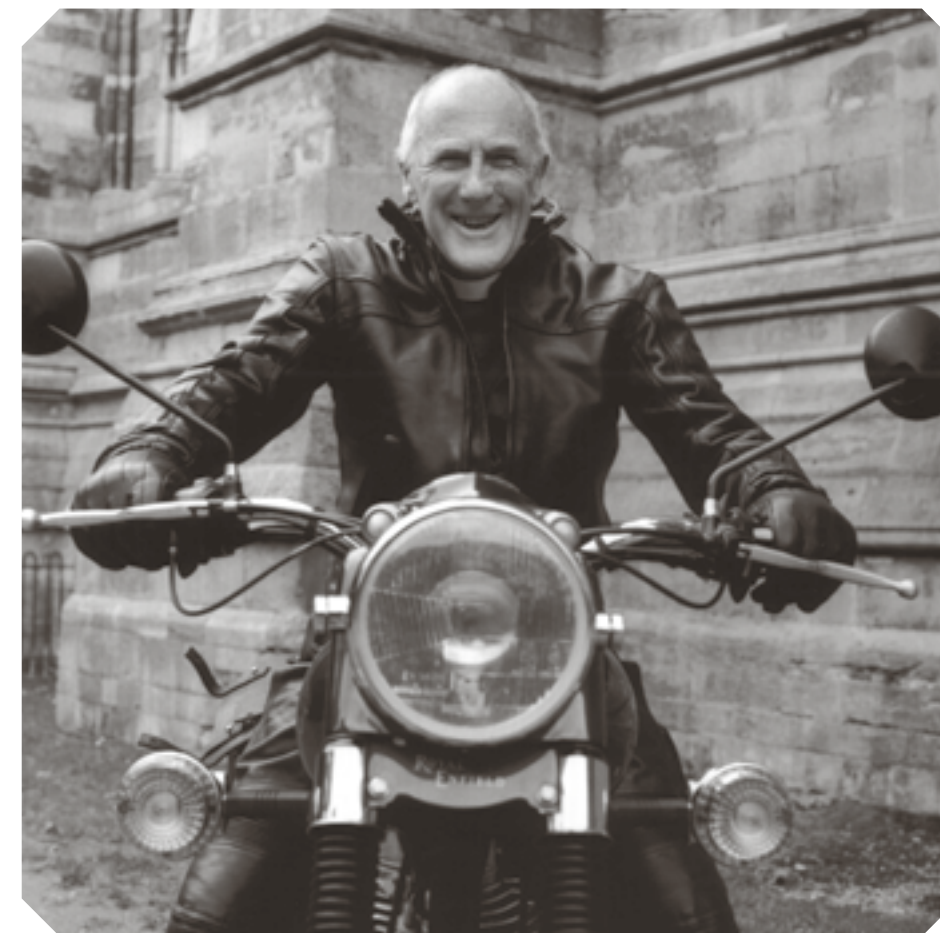
Next morning in church I deliberately offered my bike to God and asked Him to make use of it in His work. It was a prayer which has been answered in a way I could never have dreamed of.

For the next two or three years I used the bike for pottering around my parish, but the thought never entered my head that one day I would start a club for motor cyclists. Most of my time was taken up with the youth club, which had just been launched by the Revd. John Oates. Perhaps I ought to say a word about this club because it answers the question of why the club is called the 59.”



In the 1960s, the 59 Club was the biggest, most famous motorcycle club in the world, and a notorious hangout for outcasts and misfits. Half a century later, the incredible story of a gang of hoodlums and a pair of leather-clad vicars continues to amaze.

TEXT: STUART BAKER PHOTO: TOMMY



— FATHER GRAHAM HULLET —

The 59 Club London's outlaws

IF YOU RODE a motorcycle and wore a black leather jacket in London in the 1960s, there were few places you'd be welcome. The Biker Boys of the time had such a bad reputation that most cafés, cinemas and clubs banned them. The only place they could congregate was at a truck stop in North London called the Ace Café. There, the original ton-up boys would work on their bikes, swap tales of riding exploits, eat greasy trucker food and take part in illegal burn-ups. A favourite pastime was to put a rock'n' roll record on the jukebox and race each other round the block, trying to get back before the song had finished.

If you didn't ride a bike and didn't adhere to the ritual dress code of leather jacket, duck's arse hair-cut and battered jeans, you didn't dare go to The Ace. Many citizens were terrified to even pass the place. In polite society, these disaffected young men had no friends. They were outcasts, despised and feared in equal measure.

Like everyone else, the late Father Shergold (1919—2009) feared the Rockers who hung out at The Ace but, being a keen bike rider himself, he felt they could be 'saved' from a life of crime if they had some purpose and somewhere to belong. In the November 1966 issue of Link – the magazine of The 59 Club – Father Shergold recalled:

Because of their dress, their noisy bikes and their tendency to move in gangs, nobody wanted them. Dance halls refused them, bowling alleys told them to go home. Youth clubs were afraid of them. Even transport cafés didn't welcome their custom and being.

Shergold wanted to go to the Ace and give out religious posters for the benefit of the bikers but feared the reception he would get. Eventually he decided to try. Concealing his dog collar under a white scarf, he rode off on his Triumph Speed Twin. Father Shergold's recollection of the trip shows the terror which the Biker Boys instilled.

Just past Staples Corner about a dozen bikes, ridden by sinister figures in black leathers, roared past in the opposite direction. I felt sick with fear. By the time I reached the bridges at Stonebridge Park I was in such a panic I opened the throttle and fled past the Ace as fast as I could. I realised I

was being a coward, so I turned back. Again panic seized me and I went past. Then I turned back again and finally rode into the forecourt. By now, the Ace was practically deserted but I consoled myself that I had at least penetrated into the lions' den, even if the lions were out on the prowl.

Father Shergold returned a few weeks later, armed with leaflets and making no attempt to hide his dog collar.

It was packed. Hundreds of boys were milling around, laughing and talking. I thought, "This is it. I shall almost certainly lose my trousers or land up in the canal".

But there was no need to worry about getting a dunking. Father Shergold was treated with every courtesy and was amazed at the positive reaction he got when he invited the bikers to attend a special service specifically for bikers at his church the following evening. Father Shergold arranged to

have various bikes on display in the church itself and, some bikers even wheeled their machines into the church to be blessed!

The service was packed, and the incongruous sight of dangerous, law-breaking bikers attending church proved irresistible to the media. "In my address I compared the motorcyclist to the knights of old," said Shergold later, "and suggested we should try to uphold the same ideals of courage, courtesy and chivalry."

The following day, Father Shergold's service was all over the television news, and headlines in the national press proclaimed 'Ton-Up Bikes Blessed', 'Ton-Up Kids in Church' and 'Pictures of 100mph Gang that may cause a Storm.'

Impressed by the turnout, Father Shergold realised the Bike Boys needed a place where they could hang out and socialise. Father Shergold had already been involved with a church-run youth club

*“ I started riding at 14 and had my first endorsements
before I got my licence ”*

called The 59 Club, which had been founded by the Reverend John Oates. It was opened in 1959 by Cliff Richard and Princess Margaret, and Cliff and The Shadows (*who had just hit it big with the single Move It*) played at the opening night. The club was based at the Eton Mission in Hackney Wick and Father Shergold thought it would be an ideal place for his Bike Boys to hang out. In October 1962, the first bikers night was held and attended by around 100 riders. Things just grew from there. The Bike Boys kept the name of the youth club even though theirs was a separate venture. Within a few years they would make the name famous the world over. The 59 Club grew into the biggest bike club in the world with more than 11,000 members, and the club's roundel badge with the number '59' in the centre became the envy of bikers everywhere.

It was in the same year of that first meeting – 1962 – that Father Shergold brought in another

priest, Father Graham Hullett, to help him run the club. By then there were so many members that new premises had to be found and the club moved its HQ to Paddington in central London. Father Graham also rode a bike and he too saw something in the bikers that the rest of society failed – or refused – to see.

These were the same kind of lads who would have been flying Spitfires or bombers in defence of their country 20 years earlier," he says now. "Other members of the church thought myself and Father Shergold were very brave, but we weren't really - we were just mixing with people who rode bikes. Being a biker myself, I saw these lads as being just as good as anyone else. They had a different way of life but they were just as good as the rest of mankind.

Father Hullett soon became heavily involved in the club, and gained a reputation as a man who would do anything to help those in trouble.

He used his own money to bail wayward members out of jail, he broke up fights and smoothed nasty situations over, and even loaned his own money so that 59ers who were broke could take part in the annual pilgrimage to the Isle of Man TT races. One member who remembers his kindness is Len Paterson who, as a 17-year-old, was a self-confessed delinquent who was heading for a long stretch in prison before the 59 Club saved him.

Even before he gained his bike licence, Paterson had black marks against him. *"I started riding at 14 and had my first endorsements before I got my licence,"* he remembers. Paterson was unemployed when Father Hullett discovered he was so broke he couldn't join his fellow club members at the TT. Hullett loaned him the equivalent of two weeks wages to go to the races.

"I had a fantastic time at the TT, says Paterson, and I've been eternally grateful to Father Graham



— FATHER BILL SHERGOLD —



for the chance to go. He was a rock and he was one of us. Although he wore a dog collar, he was really approachable and he never once talked about God or religion to me he seemed happier talking about bikes.

It took him two years, but Paterson paid back every penny. He also remembers Father Hullett helping him out of a more desperate situation. When one club fight got out of hand and ended up with Paterson severing another man's jugular, Father Hullett again came to the rescue. "The guy was lying on the floor with a fountain of blood spouting out of his neck," recalls Paterson. "I thought I'd killed him." But Father Paterson somehow sorted it all out, the guy survived and it didn't go to court. I had already been nicked for threatening behaviour and actual bodily harm and had that gone to court my life would have been totally different. I was a yob and would have ended up in prison had it not

been for Father Graham.' There were other times when Father Hullett faced down violence. He once tried to stop a member of The Road Rats biker gang coming into the club with a shotgun, breaking the gun-toting biker's fingers as he pushed him back.

The Road Rats were a good group, but our club had a policy of only letting in real bikers or pillions. The Road Rats were mainly bikers but they had a lot of hangers on. I used to stand at the door and let in the genuine bikers while refusing entry to others. I got nervous because I knew some of them had shotguns. One time a biker I knew well shot and killed another biker on Chelsea Bridge. I was pretty nervous most nights.

But even the toughest of the Bike Boys respected Father Hullett, says Paterson.

There was one guy who shot somebody and stuck an axe in another guy's head. He wasn't the most pleasant of people but he had a tremendous

amount of respect for Father Hullett. That speaks volumes about the kind of guy Father Hullett is.

While the threat of violence was never very far away, the club was more about having fun and blowing off steam than it was about fighting. Len Paterson has many fond memories of the illegal 'burn-ups' from Chelsea Bridge to the 59 Club's headquarters in Paddington and back again. "The burn-ups from Chelsea Bridge to the 59 Club and back were legendary. Edgware Road, Park Lane, Sloane Square on a Saturday night, they were unreal. Every one of us was taking our lives in our hands. How most of us survived I don't know. The soldiers used to come out of the army barracks in Chelsea and sit on the wall to watch this lunacy. Imagine 40 or 50 bikes all racing as hard as they could through the streets of London. You couldn't do it now but the cops pretty much left us alone back then. There was no quarter asked or given



either — we were on the wrong side of the road, scratching round corners, forcing cars onto the pavement. You just had to get back to Chelsea Bridge first. It was madness but it was fantastic.

The classic Rocker image and bad boy reputation was a magnet when it came to pulling girls too. Now happily married with children, Len Paterson remembers the fringe benefits of club membership. "The club was great for pulling birds," he says.

All the waifs and strays who came to London ended up either at Chelsea Bridge or the 59 Club. The standard line was, 'Do you want to have a go on the Big Dipper in Battersea Park?' They always said yes, thinking we were talking about the funfair - but we were talking about our nobs!"

Now retired, Father Hullett left the club in the early 1970s over an internal dispute which he is too gentlemanly to discuss. By 1980, he was forced to sell his bike because he could no

longer afford to run it. He had always wanted to get back on two wheels but funds simply didn't permit. Len Paterson finally saw his chance to show his gratitude. He secretly contacted other old members of the club and asked 59 of them to donate £59 each to get Father Hullett back

of club members from the 1960s who he hadn't seen in decades were waiting in hiding. Every one of them had a reason to thank the man who had improved their lives - and quite possibly saved them in some cases. When they came through the factory doors and cheered, Father Hullett was

completely taken aback. There was more to come. Sitting in the factory was a new Sixty-5 Royal Enfield Bullet complete with custom 'Spirit of 59 Club' logo on the tank. Father Hullett was literally speechless when told the bike was his and all his riding gear and insurance was taken

care of. His 25-year dream of getting back onto two wheels was about to come true.

"I was speechless when I was presented with the new bike," says Father Hullett, "and I'm still on a high about it nearly a year later. It was a total surprise, and to have all the old club members hiding there waiting to greet me... It was just the greatest day of my life."

“Scratching around corners, forcing cars onto the pavement”

on the road. "When I started talking to people to raise the money, I realised how many of them Father Graham had helped. I thought he was just helping out a few of us but it turns out he was at it everywhere, doing whatever he could do to help."

In May 2005, BBC Radio 4's Home Truths programme followed Hullett on a nostalgic tour of the Royal Enfield factory. Unknown to him, scores